

# Perfect and continuous tenses

THESE TENSES GIVE MORE INFORMATION ABOUT WHEN AN ACTION IS HAPPENING, AND HOW LONG IT GOES ON FOR.

The perfect tenses refer to actions that are completed over a period of time. The continuous tenses are used to emphasize that an action is ongoing at a particular point in time.

## The present perfect tense

The perfect tenses describe actions that span a period of time but have a known end. The present perfect tense refers either to an action that happened at an unspecified time in the past, or to an action that began in the past and continues in the present. It is formed using the past participle, preceded by the auxiliary verb form *have* or—for the third person singular—*has*.

This refers to an action that happened at some point in the past.

**I have disappeared**  
**You have disappeared**  
**She has disappeared**

**We have disappeared**  
**You have disappeared**  
**They have disappeared**

This refers to an action that began in the past and continues in the present.

**She has lived** here for ten years.

The third person singular is formed using *has* instead of *have*.

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### GLOSSARY

**Auxiliary verb** A “helping” verb like *be* or *have* that links the main verb in a sentence to the subject.

**Past participle** The form of a verb that usually ends in -ed or -en.

**Present participle** The form of a verb that ends in -ing.

## The past perfect tense

The past perfect tense describes an action that happened in the past before something else happened. It is formed in the same way as the present perfect tense, but using the auxiliary verb form *had* before the past participle.

**I had escaped**  
**You had escaped**  
**It had escaped**

**We had escaped**  
**You had escaped**  
**They had escaped**



By the time the guard **noticed**, I **had escaped**.

This action finished before the second action (the guard noticing) started.



## The future perfect tense

The future perfect tense describes an action that will occur at some point in the future before another action. For example, “He will have offended again before we catch him.”

**I will have offended**  
**You will have offended**  
**He will have offended**

**We will have offended**  
**You will have offended**  
**They will have offended**

This tense is formed using the past participle, preceded by *will have*.